

HubSpot Newsletter Audit

What's working, what isn't, and what to do next across PnP's newsletters, locations and contacts.

Period: 1 Oct 2025 – 30 Sep 2026 · Data pulled read-only from HubSpot on 8 Oct 2026 · Prepared by Felipe Cárdenas

3/10

HubSpot email health score
Was 5–6 at the start of 2026

3.26%

Click rate (main KPI)
✓ In line with B2B benchmark
(≥3%)

1.03M

Emails sent in 12 months
1,032 different emails · –22% vs
last year

0.81%

Unsubscribe rate
▲ +72% vs last year (good ≤
0.2%)

1.29%

Hard bounce rate
▲ +97% vs last year (good ≤
0.5%)

14%

Billed contacts who engaged in
12 months
81.6k of 590k marketing contacts

The 3 things to know

1. **People who read our emails click.** Click-to-open is a healthy 12%, and the Japan newsletter and small targeted lists perform very well.
2. **Imported lists are damaging the whole account.** Three large sends to imported lists in Aug–Sep caused **half of all unsubscribes** and **~80% of bounces**.
3. **We pay for a lot of people who never engage.** 86% of billed marketing contacts haven't opened or clicked in a year, and we're at **93.7% of our HubSpot contact tier**.

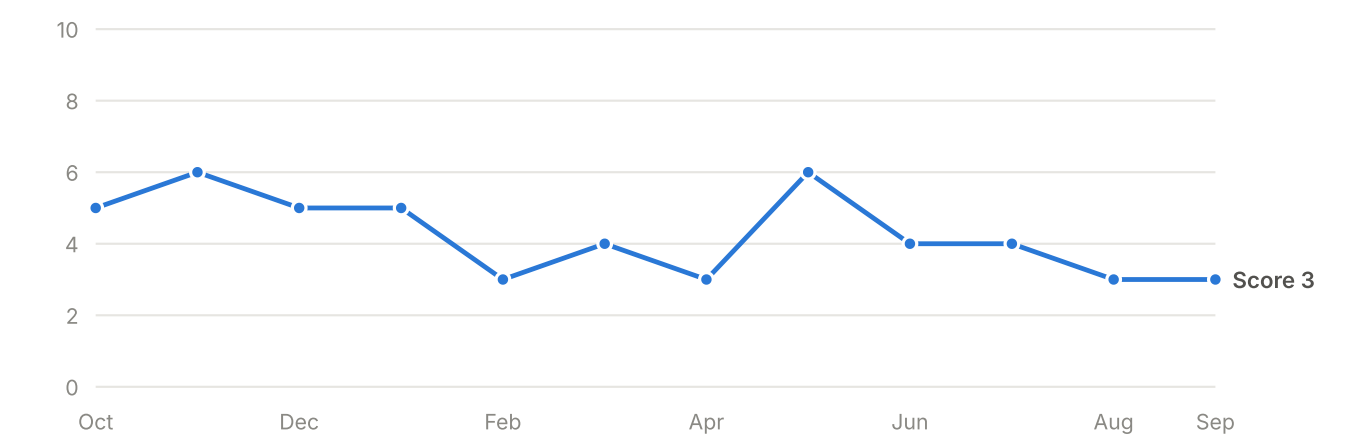
Biggest opportunity: clean the list and give each newsletter its own subscription option. That means better inbox placement, fewer people unsubscribing from *everything*, and a lower HubSpot bill.

How our emails perform

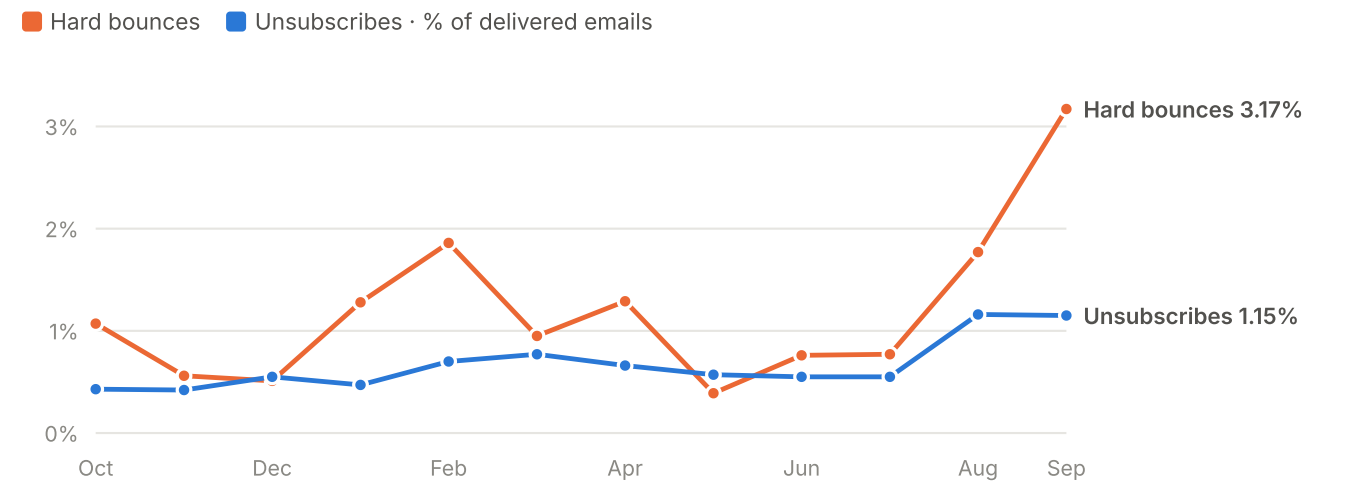
Engagement is solid. List health is the problem, and it got worse in August–September.

Metric (all marketing emails, 12 months)	PnP	Good if	vs last year	Status
Click rate (main KPI)	3.26%	≥ 3%	-1.6%	✓ Good
Click-to-open rate	12.1%	≥ 12%	+11%	✓ Good
Delivery rate	98.3%	≥ 98%	-0.8%	✓ Good
Spam reports	0.01%	< 0.1%	+78% (tiny base)	✓ Good
Hard bounces	1.29%	≤ 0.5%	+97%	! Watch
Unsubscribes	0.81%	≤ 0.2%	+72%	✗ Fix
Open rate (trend only)	26.9%	–	-11%	trend only

HubSpot email health score by month, Oct 2025 – Sep 2026 (out of 10)



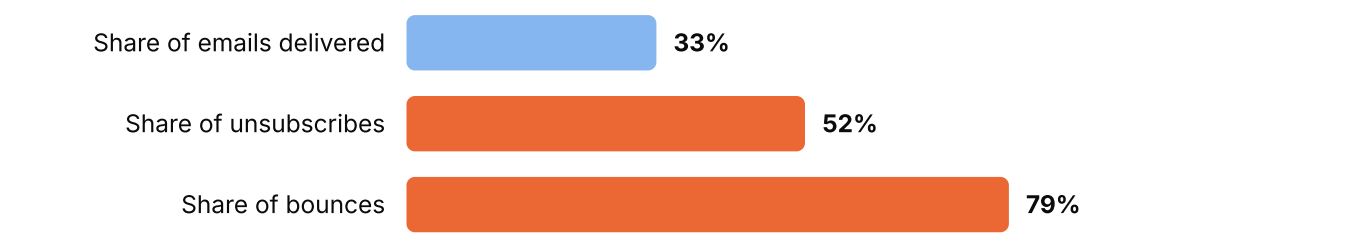
Hard bounces and unsubscribes by month, Oct 2025 – Sep 2026



Open rates are inflated: 54% of all opens came from “Other” devices with zero clicks (Apple Mail privacy and security scanners), so clicks are the KPI to watch. Source: HubSpot Analyze & Health tabs.

Imported lists and inactive contacts

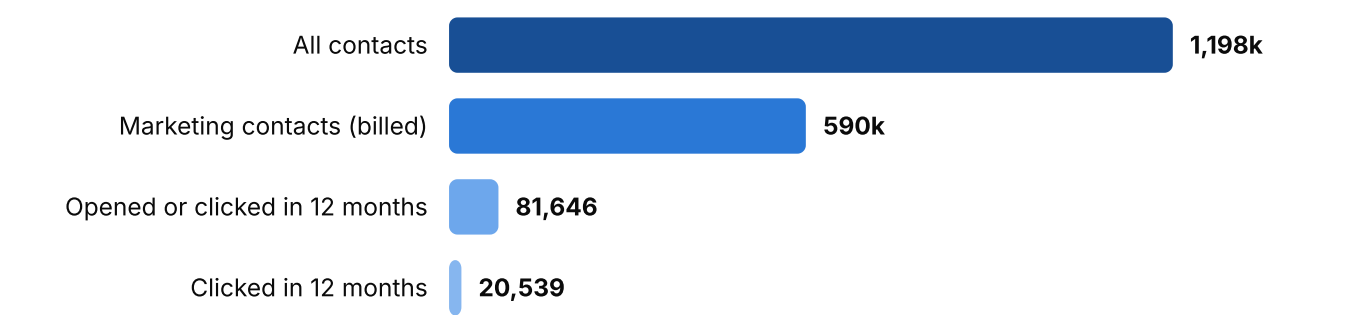
3 sends to imported lists vs. all emails (6 Aug – 30 Sep 2026)



Email	Delivered	Bounce rate	Unsub rate
Japan – Sansan list consent mail	38,385	8.5%	1.9%
Corporate Partnership Survey – 3rd batch	13,111	5.9%	1.9%
Alibaba CoCreate – startup email	18,358	4.3%	2.3%

These lists hadn't been validated, and many people on them never asked to hear from us. Gmail, Yahoo and Microsoft now filter or reject senders with poor list quality, so this affects **every** PnP newsletter, not just these sends.

How many contacts actually engage?



590,458 marketing contacts are billed, which is **93.7%** of the 630,000 tier. The next billing update is 31 Oct 2026.

433,657 marketing contacts have **never opened** a PnP email. They're the first candidates to set as non-marketing.

3 · NEWSLETTERS

Who sends what, and how it performs

Recurring newsletters with 300+ recipients, sorted by click rate (latest sends, Aug–Sep 2026).

Newsletter · sender · frequency	Avg. sent to	Click rate	Unsub rate	Status
Cyprus Latest News · Victoria from Plug and Play Cyprus · Monthly	309	10.4%	1.94%	✗ Fix
Japan Newsletter · Plug and Play Japan · Every 2 weeks	989	9.6%	0.05%	✓ Good
APAC Newsletter · Plug and Play APAC · Monthly	2,756	3.0%	0.36%	! Watch
Texas Newsletter · Francis from Plug and Play · Monthly	4,746	2.9%	0.65%	✗ Fix
Global Newsletter (GNL) · Jacky from Plug and Play · Monthly	5,748	2.4%	0.53%	✗ Fix
Seattle Community Newsletter · Emmanuel Chan · Monthly	1,787	2.2%	0.56%	✗ Fix
Startup Autobahn Monthly · STARTUP AUTOBAHN powered by Plug and Play · Monthly	4,384	2.1%	0.34%	! Watch
Türkiye Newsletter · Zeynep from Plug and Play · Monthly	1,420	1.9%	0.56%	✗ Fix
Central Asia & Caucasus Latest News · Sofi from Plug and Play Central Asia and Caucasus · Monthly	3,302	1.5%	0.76%	✗ Fix
Indiana Medtech + Lifetech Newsletter · Plug and Play Indiana · Monthly	1,430	1.3%	0.56%	✗ Fix
Italy Newsletter · Tommaso Maschera · Monthly	6,624	1.3%	0.96%	✗ Fix
UK Newsletter · Kieran Borrett · Monthly	6,474	1.1%	0.98%	✗ Fix
Foundation Newsletter · Dominique Reese · Monthly	805	0.7%	0.99%	✗ Fix
Fintech & AI Fund Insights · Brooke Ballinger · New (Edition 2 in Sep)	8,611	0.7%	1.42%	✗ Fix
Startup Autobahn Alumni Newsletter · STARTUP AUTOBAHN powered by Plug and Play · Monthly	612	0.5%	0.49%	✗ Fix

Good = click rate $\geq 3\%$ and unsubscribes $\leq 0.2\%$ per send. Fix = click rate $< 1.5\%$ or unsubscribes $> 0.5\%$. Also seen, with small lists: Brand & Retail (BRAM) Newsletter, AgTech & Animal Health Alumni/Mentor Newsletter, Supply Chain (SLAM) Innovation Brief, Mentor Newsletters (Minnesota Sustainability & NMP), UK Mobilise Monthly Update, Shamrock Foods Monthly Signal (client).

Copy this: the Japan newsletter goes out every 2 weeks, has its own subscription type, gets ~10% clicks and almost no unsubscribes. Small, targeted lists (events, mentors, finalists) also get 5–75% clicks.

Fix this: UK, Italy and Fintech & AI Insights lose ~1% of their list every send, with ~1% clicks. Most location newsletters send under the shared “Marketing Communications” type, so unsubscribing from one removes people from **all** PnP marketing.

How locations use HubSpot

✓ Good

Sending, own subscription type (5)

Silicon Valley / Global

Japan

APAC

Startup Autobahn (Stuttgart)

Foundation

! Watch

Sending, shared type (14)

UK

Italy

Texas

Seattle

Indiana

Türkiye

Central Asia & Caucasus

Cyprus

Finland

France

Warsaw

Middle East

Tirana

Minnesota

No sends seen

Team exists, no sends (14)

Los Angeles

Hamburg

Munich

Frankfurt

Spain (Barcelona / Valencia)

Alberta

Arizona

Amsterdam

Cleveland

Toronto / Canada

South Africa / Africa

Brazil / LATAM

Savannah

Basel / Switzerland

No email has a team assigned in HubSpot, so location was matched by email name and sender. "No sends seen" covers the Aug-Sep window only.

Vertical newsletters

Newsletter	Avg. sent to	Click rate	Unsub rate	Status
Fintech & AI Fund Insights	8,611	0.7%	1.42%	✕ Fix
Indiana Medtech + Lifetech Newsletter	1,430	1.3%	0.56%	✕ Fix
Brand & Retail (BRAM) Newsletter	126	3.2%	0.53%	Small list
AgTech & Animal Health Alumni/Mentor Newsletter	219	1.8%	0.00%	Small list
Supply Chain (SLAM) Innovation Brief	54	9.3%	0.00%	Small list

17 vertical newsletter types (Health, Deeptech, Smart Cities, Sustainability, Mobility...) are archived. Only Fintech & AI, Brand & Retail and Travel & Hospitality are active.

HubSpot setup check

Setting	Today	Should be	Status
Don't send to unengaged contacts	ON	ON	✓ Good
Unsubscribe feedback survey	OFF, so we don't know why people leave	ON	✕ Fix
Team / location on each email	None of 1,042 emails	Every email	✕ Fix
Subscription types	14 active, 81 archived	One per newsletter, clearly named	! Watch
Email workflows	251 ON, 65 not updated since before 2024	Reviewed, outdated ones OFF	! Watch
Double opt-in (EU)	Not in use	ON for EU sign-ups	! Watch

Recommendations

Quick wins · 0–1 month

- No sends to imported lists (1,000+) without validation, confirmed consent and a test batch.
- Turn ON the unsubscribe survey.
- Set never-engaged contacts (12+ months) to non-marketing, starting with bounced ones.
- Report click and unsubscribe rate monthly, not opens.
- Switch off outdated workflows (e.g. COVID-era ebooks).

Medium · 1–3 months

- One subscription type per location / vertical newsletter.
- Naming convention + team on every email (location reporting).
- Re-engagement ("sunset") workflow for inactive contacts.
- Shared newsletter calendar and owners, plus a frequency cap.
- Shorter emails, one call-to-action, separate startup and corporate content.
- Double opt-in for EU sign-ups.

Bigger · 3+ months

- One preference centre: choose locations, verticals and frequency.
- Welcome email series for new contacts.
- One monthly "Industry Insights" email with sections per vertical, instead of many separate newsletters.

Proposed next steps

- 1 **Agree on list rules** with the location leads: no unvalidated imports, test batches first.
- 2 **Ask a HubSpot admin** to turn on the unsubscribe survey and review the never-engaged contacts (cost check before 31 Oct).
- 3 **Confirm newsletter owners** using the newsletter map, and start a shared calendar.
- 4 **Pilot the new setup** (own subscription type, naming, team) with 2–3 location newsletters, e.g. UK, Italy, Texas.
- 5 **Re-measure in 90 days:** health score, unsubscribe and bounce rate, marketing contacts.

About this audit. Read-only, and nothing in HubSpot was changed. Newsletter details are based on the latest 100 of 1,042 emails (Aug–Sep 2026). A full-year email export would complete the map, including quarterly newsletters. Benchmarks are B2B ranges plus the Gmail/Yahoo/Microsoft sender rules. The full data is in the companion spreadsheet *PNP_HubSpot_Newsletter_Audit.xlsx*.